WEEK 02 / HISTORICAL FOUNDATIONS

Arcades and Location-Based Gaming

A look at the rise of arcades and public gaming culture.

This week, we take a look at the rise of arcades and public gaming culture. We will explore how arcades served as social hubs and influenced gaming trends, as well as the impact of location-based games on player interaction and community building.

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23 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Arcades and Public Play

REQUIRED

History of Coin-Operated Arcade Games

ARTICLE | 10 MIN

https://www.betson.com/the-history-of-arcade-games/

This article chronicles the evolution of the coin-operated gaming industry, tracing its journey from early amusement halls filled with pinball and slot machines to the modern era of family entertainment centers. The narrative highlights how pioneering titles like Pong and Space Invaders catalyzed the Golden Age of Arcades, a period defined by the introduction of iconic mascots and diverse genres ranging from maze chases to platformers. It further explores the shift toward competitive culture through versus fighting games in the 1990s and analyzes how the rise of home consoles eventually forced arcades to reinvent themselves as nostalgic "barcades" or multifaceted social hubs. Ultimately, the article serves to honor the technological and cultural legacy of the arcade, asserting that these public spaces laid the essential foundation for the global video game industry of today.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

REQUIRED

Insert Coin

YOUTUBE | 10 MIN

https://youtu.be/GUN2bP8XQKI?si=i_2qOJQig0sj3Hsy&t=2036

Watch from 33:56 to 43:55, which discusses Mortal Kombat. This documentary chronicles the golden age and eventual decline of Midway Games, a rebellious force in the video game industry that prioritized aggressive, boundary-pushing innovation over traditional rules. It traces the company's evolution from the early success of titles like Defender through the industry crash of 1984, highlighting how they reclaimed dominance by pioneering video digitization to create realistic, gritty experiences in NARC and Mortal Kombat. Key themes include the intense internal competition between design teams, the "punk rock" defiance of cultural norms regarding video game violence, and the massive commercial impact of licensed hits like NBA Jam. Ultimately, the documentary illustrates a technological and cultural shift, as the rise of home consoles and the internet

dismantled the social arcade scene, leading Midway to pivot away from its coin-operated roots.

LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

REQUIRED

The Future of Arcades is Weirder Than You Think

YOUTUBE | 47 MIN

https://youtu.be/LFaxqJJLOZc?si=gVuHUssWo2kROvGq

This video examines the modern evolution of the arcade industry, tracing its decline from a turnkey retail business to its current transformation into a social entertainment hub. By analyzing major chains like Chuck-E-Cheese and Dave and Busters, the video illustrates how physical venues are pivoting toward sports, hospitality, and communal experiences to compete with the convenience of home consoles. It highlights innovative newcomers like OS, which prioritizes physical community building over high-tech hardware, and 1,000 Boxes, a startup utilizing a software-as-a-service model to deliver unique, host-led group games. Ultimately, the video argues that the survival of out-of-home gaming depends on creating immersive, non-replicable social interactions that cannot be experienced through a screen alone.

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LO 8: Students will be able to discuss potential future trends in gaming, reflecting on emerging technologies, cultural shifts, and player expectations.

REQUIRED

What is Location-Based Entertainment - A Clear Explanation

ARTICLE | 12 MIN

https://drawandcode.com/learning-zone/what-is-location-based-entertainment/

This comprehensive guide defines location-based entertainment (LBE) as a thriving industry that delivers immersive, destination-specific experiences by blending elements of hospitality, retail, and cutting-edge technology. The text explores the sector's structure by categorizing various venues-ranging from traditional theme parks and arcades to modern escape rooms and VR centers-while highlighting the virtual and augmented reality foundations that drive engagement. Strategically, the article examines the market's rapid economic expansion and the design principles of storytelling and interactivity that distinguish these physical attractions from home-based media. Ultimately, it serves to educate businesses on the revenue potential and future innovations of the "experience economy," where consumers increasingly prioritize memorable, shared activities over material goods.

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REQUIRED

What is "location-based" VR?

YOUTUBE | 4 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JCKwAznXaSM&ab_channel=MakayplaysVR

This video provides a comprehensive overview of location-based experiences (LBE), which are specialized physical venues designed to host immersive virtual reality adventures. The creator explains that these destinations provide all necessary equipment and often feature multisensory enhancements, such as physical

props, haptic feedback, and environmental effects like wind or scents to deepen the sense of realism. By highlighting specific industry leaders like The Void, Dreamscape, and Sandbox VR, the narrative illustrates how these businesses transform digital gaming into social, high-tech excursions that far exceed the capabilities of home setups. Ultimately, it serves as an educational guide for newcomers, detailing the variety of available interactive attractions found in malls, theme parks, and modern arcades.

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REQUIRED

PROJECTIONS: Spaces' Location-Based VR Experience

YOUTUBE | ~24 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=U9qiUundJ8c

Watch at least the first 24 minutes. This video features a discussion from the show "Projections," where hosts review Spaces, a novel location-based virtual reality (LBVR) experience situated in a movie theater lobby. The video highlights how this "tactile" entertainment model allows groups of four to engage in a physical environment mapped to a Terminator-themed digital world, utilizing high-end gear like haptic vests, backpack PCs, and facial mapping technology. Beyond the specific game mechanics, the video provides an interview with the company's CTO, who outlines the industry's shift toward social, IP-driven attractions that offer sensory experiences-such as physical props and environmental effects-unobtainable in a home setting. Ultimately, the conversation explores the economic and technical challenges of high-end VR, contrasting these expensive, collaborative theater installations with more accessible home gaming options like the Oculus Go and the VR adaptation of Angry Birds.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Arcades : The Universal Language : 1970-1999 (Directors Cut)

YOUTUBE | ~27 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v8rhq5YKJPg

Watch at least the first 27 minutes. Feel free to watch more. The video's description includes links to chronological "chapters" in the video. The video is 10 hours long, so don't watch the whole thing! This documentary serves as a chronological history of arcade gaming, evolving from its early 20th-century origins into a global cultural phenomenon spanning the 1970s and 1980s. The video details the industry's transition from mechanical penny arcades and pinball to the birth of the video game era, highlighted by foundational titles like Pong, Space Invaders, and Pac-Man. Key themes include the fierce competition between industry giants like Atari, Nintendo, and Namco, the technological shift toward microprocessors and vector graphics, and the social transformation of arcades from "seedy" establishments into family-friendly entertainment centers. Ultimately, it preserves the legacy of the Golden Age of gaming, illustrating how early innovations in genres and hardware established the universal language of modern interactive entertainment.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.
LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.

EXPLORE FURTHER

The Arcade Project: A Cultural History of Gaming Spaces

YOUTUBE | ~70 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nkm8_2hb9VQ&ab_channel=CSULBCenterfortheHistoryofVideoGamesandCriticalPlay

The Digital Arcade Project examines how racial segregation and urban geography shaped the accessibility of gaming spaces in Los Angeles County between 1977 and 1987. By layering arcade locations over 1980 census data, the researchers reveal that high-end "primary" and "secondary" venues were intentionally situated in white suburban peripheries and along freeway corridors, effectively isolating communities of color. This physical distance was reinforced by discriminatory zoning laws and a popular media narrative that framed arcades as wholesome, middle-class environments while branding inner-city "quaternary" play spaces as illicit or dangerous. Ultimately, the study demonstrates how the distribution of video games functioned as a form of fiscal and social discrimination, reflecting broader historical efforts to regulate and restrict the leisure of non-white populations.

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LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

EXPLORE FURTHER

The Ted Dabney Experience Podcast

PODCAST

https://www.teddabneyexperience.com/

The Ted Dabney Experience is a historical podcast dedicated to preserving the legacy of the golden age of video arcades through in-depth interviews. Hosted by a trio of veteran experts-journalist Paul Drury, world-record gamer Tony Temple, and illustrator Richard May-the program captures the firsthand accounts and memories of industry pioneers. By collaborating with the American Classic Arcade Museum, the show aims to document the evolution of gaming culture and the untold stories of its legendary creators. Listeners and industry veterans alike praise the project for its professional storytelling and its essential role in safeguarding the oral history of digital entertainment.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The History of Atari: 1971-1977

ARTICLE

https://www.gamedeveloper.com/business/the-history-of-atari-1971-1977

This long article provides a comprehensive chronological account of Atari's formative years, tracing its evolution from a small bedroom startup into a global entertainment powerhouse. The author explores how Nolan Bushnell applied the strategic depth of the game Go to establish a design philosophy centered on being "easy to learn, but difficult to master," which fueled the success of early hits like Pong. Structurally, the narrative navigates through key technological milestones, such as the shift from hardware-based logic to microprocessors and the eventual creation of the Atari VCS (2600). Beyond the technical achievements, the source highlights the entrepreneurial struggles and corporate culture that defined the era, including the strategic merger with Warner Communications to survive an increasingly competitive home market.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Rise and fall of Atari: Atari backstory

COMIC

https://consolers.webcomic.ws/archive/18245

A short Web comic with highlights of Atari's story.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Coin-Op Century: A Brief History of the American Arcade

ARTICLE

https://www.museumofplay.org/blog/coin-op-century-a-brief-history-of-the-american-arcade/

This article traces the evolution of the American arcade, demonstrating that these social hubs have thrived for over a hundred years through constant adaptation. The narrative moves chronologically from nineteenth-century novelty parlors and the penny arcades of the industrial era to the mid-century dominance of pinball and the explosive video game "golden age" of the late 1970s. By highlighting the shift from mechanical amusements to digital screens, the text illustrates how changing technology and shifting social demographics dictated the arcade's cultural relevance. Ultimately, the author argues that while traditional venues faced a late-century decline, the medium endures through modern entertainment centers, retro-themed bars, and museum preservation efforts.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Space Invaders: Tomohiro Nishikado Reveals Why the Main Villains Were Octopuses

ARTICLE

https://www.cbr.com/space-invaders-octopus-villains-war-worlds/

This article explores how Tomohiro Nishikado developed the iconic visual design of the 1978 arcade phenomenon, Space Invaders. Drawing from an interview in the Netflix docuseries High Score, the text explains that the game’s octopus-like enemies were directly inspired by H.G. Wells’ classic science fiction novel, The War of the Worlds. Beyond these creative origins, the piece highlights the game's massive cultural impact in Japan, noting how its popularity caused a national coin shortage and paved the way for its eventual global success on Atari home consoles. By linking childhood imagination to technical innovation, the author illustrates how a single designer's vision ignited the modern arcade boom.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Replay: The History of Video Games by Tristan Donovan

BOOK

https://www.amazon.com/Replay-History-Video-Tristan-Donovan/dp/0956507204

"A riveting account of the strange birth and remarkable evolution of the most important development in entertainment since television, Replay is the ultimate history of video games. Based on extensive research and over 140 exclusive interviews with key movers and shakers from gaming's past, Replay tells the sensational story of how the creative vision of game designers gave rise to one of the world's most popular and dynamic art forms." Chapters 1-3 and 18 are especially relevant to this week's discussions.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

1971: The Video Game Arcade is Born! Galaxy Game and Computer Space!

YOUTUBE | 5 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=flV7x26wp0U&ab_channel=ChronologicallyGaming

This video introduces a historical exploration of the year 1971, which marked the ambitious birth of the video game arcade. The source highlights two pioneering titles, Galaxy Game and Computer Space, noting that these early machines relied on transistor logic rather than modern microprocessors to function. While Galaxy Game adapted sophisticated physics and gravity simulations from mainframe computers, it lacked the commercial success of later hits. Ultimately, the video illustrates the challenges of pioneering a new medium, from establishing basic gameplay mechanics to creating marketing materials for a public that had no prior concept of an arcade cabinet.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

'The Infinite' immersive experience takes guests to space

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pkIa859O49o&ab_channel=FOX13Seattle

Located at the Tacoma Armory, "The Infinite" is a virtual reality exhibition that allows ordinary people to simulate the life of an astronaut aboard the International Space Station. Visitors use high-definition headsets to explore 360-degree cinematic environments, where they can virtually interact with crew members and experience the first-ever cinematic spacewalk recorded in the vacuum of outer space. By touching digital orbs within the simulation, participants witness the daily routines and personal struggles of those living in orbit, making the vastness of space accessible without leaving Earth. This hour-long immersive journey serves as a bridge between the public and the cosmos, offering a profoundly realistic perspective on lunar life through cutting-edge technology.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
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EXPLORE FURTHER

VR Gym and VR Gaming Arena All In One: ThriVR!

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3FI4q5I4Ik4&list=PLIpvHCj8Tnt2spgTRQqbPEdNiayRBbmT8&index=2&ab_channel=JayBratt

Located in Dallas, ThriVR is a pioneering facility that merges high-intensity physical fitness with immersive virtual reality gaming. The center features specialized equipment like gyroscopic "flying machines" for core stability, boxing robots for combat training, and omnidirectional treadmills that allow players to run through digital environments. Beyond serving as a boutique gym, the venue's primary ambition is to establish a competitive e-sports league where athletes can earn money through skill-based tournaments. By providing a professional platform for physical gaming competitions, the creators aim to democratize organized sports in the same way digital video platforms revolutionized broadcasting.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

About vrCAVE - VR for Location-Based Entertainment

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=EdhDd6FNWJI&ab_channel=vrCAVEInc.

Specializing in the development of collaborative virtual reality experiences, vrCAVE provides business owners with a robust library of in-house titles designed specifically for location-based entertainment like escape rooms and arcades. The company prioritizes social immersion over solitary play, offering a platform where diverse groups can explore fantastical environments and solve unique puzzles together without the physical limitations of traditional venues. By streamlining equipment installation and offering low-maintenance digital content, they enable global partners to deliver high-quality, untethered adventures to a wide demographic. Ultimately, the video illustrates a commitment to making accessible, high-end technology the foundation for unforgettable shared moments and thriving commercial entertainment spaces.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Visit an arcade

I encourage you to visit a local arcade this week!

EXPLORE FURTHER

Stranger Things (Netflix)

TV SERIES

https://www.netflix.com/title/80057281

This fictional series takes place in the 80's and features glimpses of arcade culture through the local fictional arcade called Palace Arcade, which is introduced in season 2.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

EXPLORE FURTHER

The Goldbergs (ABC/Hulu)

TV SERIES

https://www.hulu.com/series/a43a85fb-d4c8-4d11-9c28-070153643bec

This sitcom takes place in the 80's and features glimpses of arcade culture through the local fictional arcade called Challenge Arcade.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

EXPLORE FURTHER

High Score (Netflix)

DOCUMENTARY TV SERIES

https://www.netflix.com/title/81019087

"This documentary series about the history of classic video games features insights from the innovators who brought these worlds and characters to life."

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Bob Lawton, owner of world’s largest arcade, dies at 90

ARTICLE

https://apnews.com/article/lifestyle-new-hampshire-laconia-1e62be5b5af1d35ecc01ea4cf30b4ce7

This text serves as a tribute to Bob Lawton, the visionary entrepreneur who transformed a small loan from his grandmother into Funspot, home of the American Classic Arcade Museum and officially recognized as the world’s largest arcade. The narrative chronicles Lawton’s seven-decade legacy in New Hampshire, highlighting his community-focused persona as a man in red suspenders who treated his business like a beloved child. Beyond his contributions to the gaming industry, the article touches upon his diverse life as a military veteran and state representative, illustrating a broad commitment to public service. Ultimately, the piece acts as an obituary and a legacy statement, ensuring that Lawton’s "Walt Disney of the North" reputation lives on through his family's continued operation of the landmark.

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